



I'd find players more tactically aware but lacking some of the physical and technical attributes. Here, it's the opposite. They have the physicality, motivation, and technical skills, but they need to improve their tactical understanding — how to play zonal defence, how to react in different situations, and how to learn from repeated scenarios," he explained.

Goalkeeping conundrum

The league's five-foreigner rule may have hindered India's search for a long-term No. 1 goalkeeper. Several Indian goalkeepers were substituted for penalty strokes and shootouts, with national team regulars Krishan Pathak and Suraj Karkera having to compete with Toby Reynold-Cotterill and Oliver Payne in their respective franchises. However, the presence of experienced goalkeepers like Dominic Dixon and David Harte would have benefited junior team 'keepers such as Bikramjit Singh (Toofans) and Prince Deep Singh (Tamil Nadu Dragons).

Missed opportunities

Alongside the Tigers and Toofans, Soorma Hockey Club and Tamil Nadu

Dragons reached the semifinals. Soorma, spearheaded by veterans Harmanpreet and Vincent Vanasch, staged an impressive turnaround before falling to the Toofans.

The Dragons, meanwhile, were left rueing missed opportunities. Refereeing errors contributed to their downfall, but they ultimately fell short on the pitch. Despite leading the table for much of the tournament, they had to scramble to finish fourth. The team boasted the highest penalty corner conversion rate but couldn't provide prolific drag-flicker Jip Janssen with more opportunities in open play.

Lacklustre group stage, electrifying finale

While all teams were evenly matched, the tournament only ignited in its final week, with several group-stage fixtures proving lacklustre.

The Vedanta Kalinga Lancers and Delhi SG Pipers provided entertainment with high-scoring games, but their defensive frailties cost them a place in the final four. Meanwhile, Team Gonasika struggled with poor penalty corner execution.

Standing apart: The Pasha Gademan-coached Hyderabad Toofans was one of the most eye-catching of the eight teams in the HIL. HOCKEYINDIA

Every night, David Guetta's 'Memories' echoed through the speakers in Rourkela, with Kid Cudi's line on loop: "It's getting late, but I don't mind." The locals, however, certainly did. Despite Hockey India offering free tickets for the entire tournament, the 21,000-capacity stadium remained largely empty until the final. Late 8:15 p.m. starts meant many supporters had to leave midway to secure transport home.

The stadium sold out only for the final, where actor Sara Ali Khan headlined the closing ceremony. However, poor ticket screening left it overcrowded, with some supporters attending solely for her performance, and 4,000 spectators (some with tickets) stranded outside an hour before kickoff. Restricting the tournament to just two venues — Rourkela and Ranchi — ensured sustainability, but dwindling attendance at the former cast a shadow over what was otherwise a successful venture for the federation.